The Society Of Suitmakers

Decoding the hallmarks of bespoke menswear—proportion, craftsmanship, discipline, and longevity—with four tailors inspired by the classic sartorial codes set by London's Savile Row.

BY SHARMI ADHIKARY

As a fashion cognoscenti, you may have noticed that menswear shared the spotlight equally at this year's couture week, catering to the often untended male yen for dressing well. Eclectic creations took centrestage with designs boasting innovative details, precise tailoring, and exquisite embroideries. Inarguably, the conversation on style and silhouettes for the modern man has, at last, gathered momentum.

However, for long before this transition in India, London's Savile Row has been guarding its worldwide reputation as the Mecca for custom men's suits. The dialect at this renowned Mayfair street, where cub designers train under experts, would centre around the vocabulary pertaining to shirts, jackets, trousers, and the like. This brings us to the fabled names closer home, where the British did leave an enduring legacy in terms of fine men's tailoring.

Among its finest heirs are Syed Bawkher & Co in Chennai, Barkat Ali & Brothers in Kolkata, and Vaish at Rivoli in Delhi—establishments that continue to enjoy a formidable reputation in the realm of bespoke menswear. In fact, Syed Bawkher counts Richard Gere and AR Rahman among its patrons, while Barkat Ali famously stitched Nehru jackets for the legendary MF Husain.

This esteemed space now serves as the playground for a new wave of outfitters, four of whom speak with *India Today Spice* about their craft.

TIMELESS TAILORING

Jeet Khatri & Jeet Tailor – Tenassi, Mumbai

Keeping aside the coincidence of being each other's namesakes, Jeet Khatri and Jeet Tailor are the minds behind one of Mumbai's coolest bespoke menswear tailors, Tenassi.

"Tailoring, for me, is identity," says Tailor, the Chief Sales and Marketing Officer. "A beautifully tailored garment has the ability to change how a man carries himself before he even speaks."

As he immersed himself in the classic silhouettes for men, he realised people often associated tailoring with rigidity when in reality, there's incredible creativity hidden beneath the discipline. Every decision had a reason: why a lapel rolls a certain way, why a shoulder appears to sit naturally on one's build, why a pocket is placed millimetres higher or lower. The beauty wasn't in making loud garments but in creating something so well balanced that it became one with the wearer.

"In India," says Khatri, Tenassi's Founder and CEO, "conversations often revolve around colours, fabrics, and trends. At Savile Row [where we interacted with acquaintances from tailors Anderson & Sheppard and Henry Poole & Co], they begin with fit, proportion, and construction."

Inspired by distinctly dapper men like Cary Grant, Gianni Agnelli, and Ralph Lauren, the duo begin working on a design by first understanding an individual's profession, lifestyle, travel habits,